eyes and ignored all the sounds that were reaching my ears. Everything went dark and blank for a moment.

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June 1987

Summers in Babina were unforgiving. Papaji would take Dada and me to the swimming pool in the officers' mess in the late afternoons almost every day to deal with the scorching heat. Dada was a good swimmer and would use this opportunity to brush up on his swimming skills, whereas I would simply while away time in frivolous activities. But Papaji had a different plan for us. He had put in our names for a swimming competition scheduled at the end of the month without letting us know. He would only tell us four days prior. While it excited Dada, I was left disappointed, since I knew I would lose. Other girls of the society knew how to dive, but even though I was a good swimmer, I only knew how to jump and not dive. So Papaji started to teach me how to dive. But days passed and I still could not learn.

'I won't be able to accompany you tomorrow,' Papaji said to us after he hung up the phone and came to the dining table. The swimming competition was scheduled for the next day.

'It's good you won't have to see Gunjan fail,' Dada commented. Papaji stared at Dada angrily.

'I will not fail,' I retorted.

'Why do you think Gunjan will fail?' Papaji asked.

'She doesn't know how to dive,' Dada said. 'Others will take the lead by diving.'

'So what if she doesn't know how to dive? She will win,' Maa barged in, siding with me.

'If you want your daughter to win, tell her to dive. Even if it'll be a bad dive, it will still be better than a jump,' Dada said to Maa. He clearly didn't want me to jump. I knew his friends would make fun of him if I jumped instead of diving. That's how boys were.